

sports **BCCI VS ICL**

CRICKET'S TURF WARS

With 40 Indian players crossing over to the rebel ICL, BCCI is facing a cross-examination of its hold over Indian cricket

■ By Sharda Ugra

So, Kapil Dev has promised to go on a hunger strike. Not because he was sacked as chairman of the National Cricket Academy (NCA) but to protect the interests of someone other than himself. In itself, this scenario is unprecedented. Throw in the beloved Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), a peeved media mogul and the threat of mass rebellion and you will find enough dark drama to populate a daily soap with no extra witchery needed from either *saas* or *bahu*.

The Indian Cricket League (ICL), launched by Subhash Chandra's Essel Group this April, made its biggest rumble with the signing of 44 Indian cricketers, most of them first-class players. If the recruitment drive by ICL was meant to be a vote of confidence in BCCI, then this clutch of players voted with their feet and crossed over.

They have depleted some of India's frontline domestic teams like Hyderabad, and Bengal. In pure numbers, though, BCCI's current recruits are only 6 per cent of its registered players, its 27 Ranji teams registering 25 players per season.

The 'rebels' included several who had played for India and only a few who could be considered on the fringes of selection, either now or in a couple of years' time. Their reasons for crossing over were varied: Bengal captain Deep Dasgupta, writing in a Kolkata newspaper the next day, said players from his state had been neglected. Former India under-19 captain Ambati Rayudu and seven Hyderabad teammates were at war with their cricket association. To Bengal's promising bat Abhishek Jhunjhunwala, (among the 30 probables for the Twenty20 World Cup), financial security and the prospect of playing along-

side Brian Lara, ICL's biggest catch, were enough reasons.

ICL begins in October as a six-city league in a Twenty20 format. This, says Ashish Kaul, executive vice-president, Essel Group, is only the first step. Eventually, ICL will include "all formats including Test matches". The six cities will be expanded to all the major metros, "which in turn will act as feeders for a national team as and when we are ready", he says.

The eventual aim is to supplant BCCI which, publicly at least, remains unmoved. Their working committee met a day after ICL revealed its 50 recruits but according to an official, "we didn't spend five minutes discussing ICL. We don't know what it is."

Such sangfroid would be impressive if BCCI did not have a history of missing out on opportunity after opportunity to protect or reform itself or even smarten up its act. Ten years ago, the current BCCI vice-president, Lalit Modi among others, had proposed the creation of a city league to be played under lights in summer. At the very last minute, BCCI withdrew approval.

In June 2006, Harish Thawani, CEO of Nimbus Communications Ltd (global media rights holders for all cricket in India till 2010), made a presentation in London to senior BCCI officials. He suggested a restructuring of domestic cricket starting with scrapping all zonal formats, making brands out of domestic properties and creating a new franchise-based professional league at the top of the domestic game, to be funded by the private sector. BCCI President Sharad Pawar approved but little action followed encouraging words.

The BCCI-ICL tussle today, says an observer, is "all about who can influence the media circus more". In the propaganda war, ICL is winning hands



Photographs by BHASKAR PAUL



ADVICE NEEDED: BCCI chief Pawar (left) with I.S. Bindra in Mumbai

down—not only because it has Dev, the *badshah* of bluster, on its side. It is said ICL brought forward its mega player-signing media conference to pre-empt BCCI's planned working committee announcement. That way ICL grabbed the headlines exactly a day before BCCI announced hikes in its domestic prize money and player fees (from Rs 16,000 to Rs 35,000 per match day). The hikes